

Improving access to imported food safety requirements

Imported food safety requirements are now included in the [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#).

See more about the [Inclusion of food safety requirements in BICON](#).

All biosecurity requirements must be met before [Imported Food Inspection Scheme](#) requirements apply.

Check our [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#) for biosecurity import conditions.

We classify imported food that presents a potential medium or high risk to public health as [risk food](#). All risk food is listed in the [Imported Food Control Order 2019](#).

Finfish that is ready-to-eat is a risk food

This includes finfish that is cooked, cured or smoked and is [ready-to-eat](#).

Exclusions

- Ready-to-eat finfish that is dried, pickled, salted or fermented.
- Ready-to-eat finfish that are [retorted](#) and [shelf stable](#).
- Food from [New Zealand](#).

Declaring certificates

When lodging a [Full Import Declaration \(FID\)](#), use the correct ICS document code and certificate number for the food.

See [lodging declarations and documentation](#).

Community Protection (CP) question

You will need to answer this CP question when lodging your [full import declaration](#):

IFIS: Are the goods cooked, cured or smoked finfish that require refrigeration (frozen or chilled) and do not require further cooking before consumption?

Inspection and testing

We refer consignments of finfish that is ready-to-eat for analytical testing based on whether it supports the growth of *Listeria monocytogenes* or not.

- Finfish that supports the growth of *Listeria monocytogenes* is a risk food and referred for testing at the initial rate of 100% of consignments until compliance is demonstrated.
- Finfish that does not support the growth of *Listeria monocytogenes* is referred for testing at the rate of 5% of consignments.

During inspection, we will also conduct a visual and label assessment.

Additional requirements apply to specific seafood. See the webpages for:

Table 1 shows the tests that will be applied and permitted results for each food type.

Table 1: Food type, test applied and permitted result

Food type	Test applied	Permitted result
Finfish that supports the growth of <i>Listeria monocytogenes</i> (risk food)	<i>Listeria monocytogenes</i> <i>Listeria monocytogenes</i>	n=5, c=0, m=not detected in 25 g
Finfish that does not support the growth of <i>Listeria monocytogenes</i> (risk food)	Note: An IFIS Importer declaration needs to be lodged to provide evidence that the finfish does not support the growth of <i>Listeria monocytogenes</i> , or the finfish will be referred as finfish that supports the growth of <i>Listeria monocytogenes</i> .	n=5, c=0, m=100 cfu/g

n = the number of samples to be analysed from a lot of food.
c = the maximum number of sample units that can be greater than ‘m’.
m = the acceptable microbiological level in a sample unit.

Food safety risks

Food Standard Australia New Zealand (FSANZ) has given us [advice about the risk of processed ready-to-eat finfish](#). These products present a potential medium or high risk to public health and safety for *Listeria monocytogenes*.

Voluntary foreign government certification arrangements

We have a [voluntary certification arrangement](#) in place with Canada and Thailand for finfish that is ready-to-eat.

Consignments of these foods from Canada and Thailand with a recognised government certificate have a reduced rate of inspection and testing.

Certificate requirements

Type of information	To include
National competent authority:	Canadian Food Inspection Agency
Recognised certificate title:	Certificate of Origin and Hygiene
ICS document code:	CI

Certificate requirements

Type of information	To include
National competent authority:	Ministry of Agriculture and Cooperatives – Department of Fisheries
Recognised certificate title:	Health Certificate for fishery and aquaculture products originating in Thailand
Additional requirement:	The certificate must identify that the food has been sourced from an establishment approved by the Department of Fisheries, Thailand .
ICS document code:	DOFHCTH

Glossary

Ready-to-eat

Food is ready-to-eat if it is ordinarily consumed in the same state as that in which it is sold.

To avoid doubt, food is not ordinarily consumed in the same state as that in which it is sold if, before it is consumed, it requires further processing (such as cooking) to reduce any pathogenic microorganisms potentially present in the food to safe levels.

Retorted

Animal products are retorted if they are heated in a hermetically sealed container to a minimum core temperature of 100°C, obtaining an Fo value of at least 2.8.

Shelf stable

Goods are shelf stable if the:

- goods have been commercially manufactured
- goods have been packaged by the manufacturer
- goods are in that package
- package has not been opened or broken
- goods are able to be stored in the package at room or ambient temperature, and
- goods do not require refrigeration or freezing before the package is opened.

Version history

Date	Amendment details
23/01/2025	Amend the detail in this webpage to support the splitting of fish and crustaceans from aquaculture production.
14/06/2024	Amend the webpage to advise that finfish that does not support the growth of <i>Listeria monocytogenes</i> is still subject to testing.
12/04/2023	Amend the webpage to update the link to the list of fish processing establishments approved by the Department of Fisheries, Thailand.
10/07/2018	Updated to reflect introduction of a voluntary importer declaration.
12/10/2016	Updated requirements following risk advice provided to the department by FSANZ
1/5/2014	Replaces Imported Food Notice 09/12 Tests applied to risk category foods

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/goods/food/type/ready-to-eat-fish>